Funeral & Estate Coordination App: Business Development Plan

1. Executive Summary and Verdict

Yes, this app is beneficial, and yes, it can be built profitably — but not the way the idea is usually imagined. The research is unambiguous on one point: nobody has successfully monetized this app by charging grieving families a subscription. Lantern's $27/year model was acquired for roughly its total $1.5M raised and then shut down; Everplans' $99.99/year vault was acquired twice, both times by funeral-insurance-adjacent buyers looking for distribution, not by a standalone consumer business (CB Insights; Wellthy; Everplans). Meanwhile, the company that has actually scaled — Empathy, covering 50M+ lives and growing revenue 10x in two years — sells almost nothing to families directly. It sells a claims-cost reduction story to insurers and employers, who then give the product to families for free (Empathy; Calcalist).

Is it beneficial? Unambiguously. Every family that has lost someone faces the same fragmented mess this app proposes to solve: death certificates, Social Security, life insurance, 401(k) claims, VA benefits, probate, taxes, religious obligations, and vendor coordination scattered across a dozen institutions and a 12-24 month timeline, with almost no single family-facing tool that holds all of it together end to end. That gap is real and it is confirmed by the competitive landscape: Empathy handles post-death administrative tasks and grief support but not the funeral purchase itself; Trust & Will handles pre-death legal documents but nothing after death; After.com handles the funeral transaction but only in six states after $16.1M raised (Trust & Will FAQ; Hospice News). Nobody occupies the full death-to-one-year journey as one coordinated family workspace.

Who should it be marketed to? Families are the end users, but families should not be the first paying customer. The GTM sequence is: (1) families directly in one metro — Atlanta/Georgia is the natural home base — through search, checklists, and local coordinator/death-doula partnerships; (2) hospices, which are the highest-intent, most pre-qualified referral channel in the entire category and remain almost entirely unclaimed — the only hospice partnerships found in this research date to 2021 pilots that never scaled (Hospice News; Hospice News); (3) employers, EAPs, and life insurers as B2B2C payers once the MVP has proof; (4) nursing homes and, later, hospitals, where no partnership was confirmed for any competitor in this landscape.

How is it profitable? Not through a family subscription. The model is a one-time family coordination package (in the $99-$299 range, consistent with the surviving consumer price points in this category — Keeper $99, GoodTrust $149, Ever Loved $199.99, Trust & Will $199-599) layered with B2B2C contracts sold to employers and insurers, plus disclosed, non-commission marketplace fees from vetted vendors (Keeper pricing; GoodTrust pricing; Ever Loved support; Trust & Will help center).

How should it be developed? Start narrow and deep in one state (Georgia) with a small number of religious traditions, build the family permission/coordination workspace and the state-and-

religion checklist engine first, add the vendor and coordinator directory, and only pursue institutional partnerships and multi-state licensing complexity after the core workspace proves that families actually use and pay for it. What not to build first: a nationwide licensed funeral-arranging marketplace, a tool that gives legal advice rather than legal information, or a vendor marketplace with undisclosed referral commissions — each of these has either failed, triggered legal exposure, or both, for competitors in this exact space.

2. Why the App Is Beneficial

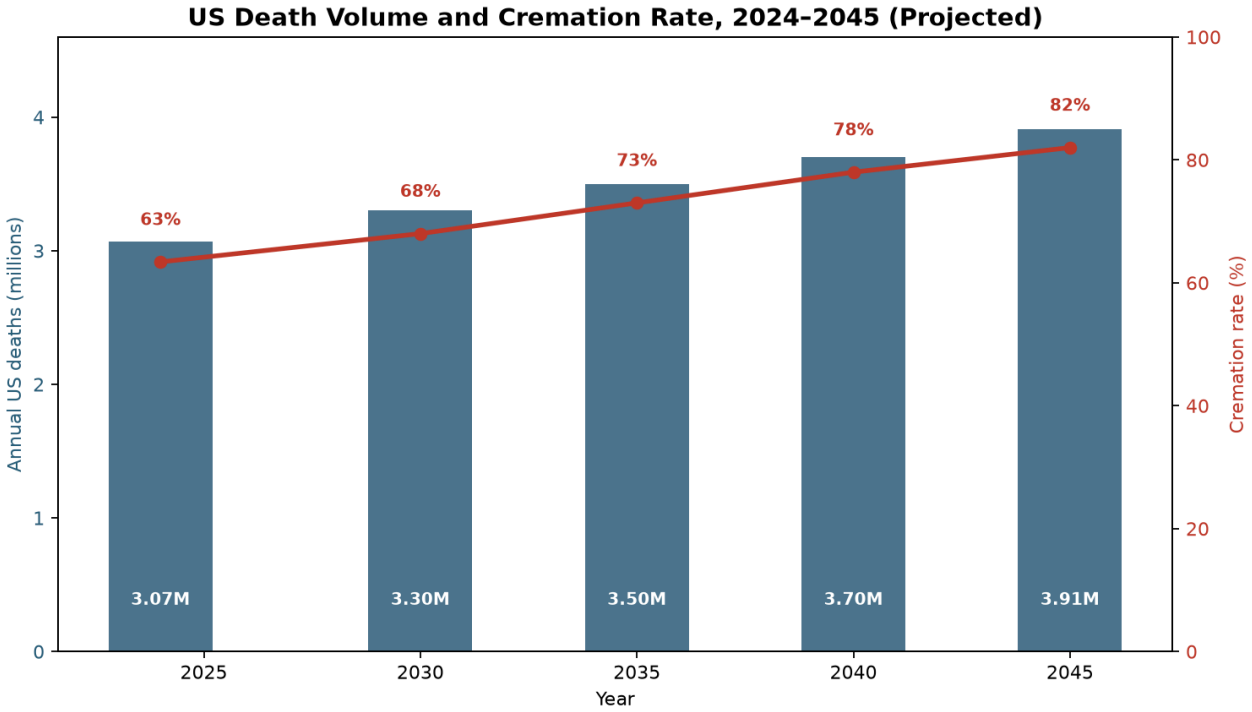
The core insight from the death-to-one-year research is that grief and bureaucracy hit families simultaneously, and the bureaucracy does not pause for the grief. In the first week alone, a family must handle pronouncement of death, choose disposition, and order 8-15 certified death certificates at $5-$25 each (HelpAfterLife), all while observing state-specific waiting periods — Texas requires 48 hours before cremation unless waived in writing by a justice of the peace or medical examiner, and Alabama imposes a 24-hour waiting period (Tex. Health & Safety Code § 716.004; Ala. Code § 34-13-121). Within a month they are reporting the death to Social Security, which offers a $255 lump-sum death benefit to a surviving spouse or qualifying child but in 2023 resulted in a payment in fewer than 38% of insured-worker deaths (SSA Pub. 05-10008; CRS R43637), and notifying credit bureaus so the deceased's credit file can be sealed (Equifax). Within the first three months they are filing life insurance claims, which nearly half of states require to be paid within 30 days of receipt of proof of death (Law Commentary); claiming 401(k) beneficiary funds, which typically require a death certificate and proof of relationship (IRS, Retirement Topics – Death); and potentially filing for VA burial benefits of $2,000 for a service-connected death or $1,002 plus a $1,002 plot/interment allowance for a non-service-connected death, using Form 21P-530EZ, with a 2-year filing deadline for non-service-connected deaths (VA burial allowance page; VA Survivor Benefits Booklet, Feb. 2026). Probate can run 6-24 months depending on whether real property is involved (48HourProbate; LegalZoom), and the one-year mark brings a cluster of deadlines at once: Form 706 estate tax filings due within 9 months of death, extendable to 15 with Form 4768 (IRS, Instructions for Form 706); the final Form 1040 and first estate Form 1041 typically due in the April following death (IRS, estate income tax return); SSA and VA claim windows closing at two years (SSA; VA); and religious observances like the Jewish unveiling before the first yahrzeit or a Catholic anniversary Mass.

No single tool currently holds all of this. Families instead juggle a folder of paper, a phone full of contacts, group texts with relatives, and separate logins for the funeral home, the insurer, the bank, and the probate court. That fragmentation is precisely where family conflict tends to erupt — over money, over decisions, and over who is "in charge" — and it is precisely the gap this app is designed to close by giving one family member a coordinating workspace with controlled, auditable access for a small circle of helpers.

The competitive research reinforces that this is a real, underserved need rather than a crowded market: the platforms that succeeded did so by narrowly solving one piece of the puzzle (grief support, will drafting, memorial pages, direct cremation) and none of them own the full journey (Section 4).

3. Market Size and Timing

The US recorded 3,072,666 deaths in 2024 (CDC), and the National Funeral Directors Association projects this will climb to 3.91 million annual deaths by 2045 as the population ages (NFDA). Every one of those deaths triggers the multi-month, multi-institution process this app is designed to organize — meaning the addressable "event volume" is growing, not shrinking, for the next two decades.



Sources: CDC NCHS (2024 actual, 3.07M deaths); NFDA 2024 Cremation and Burial Report (2045 projection, interpolated)

The funeral and death-care industry itself is valued at roughly $23-24 billion, served by 15,401-19,000 funeral homes, about 75% of which are independent or family-owned rather than chain-operated (NFDA). The median cost of a funeral is $8,300 for burial and $6,280 for cremation (NFDA), and the cremation rate — currently 63.4% and projected to exceed 82% by 2045 — is itself a structural tailwind for a coordination app, since cremation defers and complicates memorial planning in ways burial does not, creating more decision points for the app to help organize.

The largest operator, Service Corporation International (Dignity Memorial), reported FY2025 revenue of $4.31 billion and net income of $542.8 million on 1,485 locations serving about 700,000 families a year, with a $17.0 billion preneed sales backlog (SCI Q4 2025; SCI 10-K). That scale confirms real cash flows exist in this category — the question for a new entrant is not whether money moves through death, but which layer of that money flow a coordination app can legitimately and legally capture.

On the channel side, 84% of employers plan to expand bereavement support in the next benefits cycle (Empathy 2026 Workplace Benefits Report), and 91% of SHRM-member employers already offer paid bereavement leave versus about 65% of employers nationally — meaning the institutional buyer side of this market is actively expanding its bereavement budget right now, which is the moment to build the product that channel will eventually distribute.

4. Competitor Landscape

Seventeen companies were researched across funding, business model, GTM channel, scale, and disclosed weaknesses. The condensed summary:

Company	Who pays	Model	Outcome	Channel
Empathy	Insurers, employers	Enterprise SaaS + human care managers	$162M raised; 50M+ covered lives, 100% retention	B2B2C
Lantern	Consumer $27/yr	Freemium	Acquired by Wellthy for ~total raised, then **shut down**	B2C
Cake	Nobody directly	Content/SEO, no revenue model	Acquired by Foundation Partners Group	B2C SEO
Everplans	Consumer $99.99/yr + advisors	Vault subscription	Acquired twice (NGL, then Precoa)	Hybrid
Trust & Will	Consumer $199-$599	One-time documents + $49/yr membership	$25M+ Series C 2025; 1M+ users	B2C + 145 enterprise partners
After.com	Family / insurance	Licensed cremation provider	$16.1M raised; only 6 states	B2C licensed
Everest Funeral Concierge	Insurers, employers (pennies PEPM)	Licensed funeral-director concierge, no provider commissions	Operating since 2001; "millions" covered	B2B2C
SCI	Family, ~$5,818 avg	Owned funeral homes/cemeteries	Public; $542.8M net income	Physical + preneed sales force
Bereave	Employer, <$0.75-$1.15 PEPM	Workplace bereavement SaaS	n.a.	B2B

The table above summarizes the decision-relevant competitor set; detailed profiles were used to inform the recommendations.

What is working: selling to insurers on hard claims-cost math rather than to consumers on sentiment (Empathy's pitch is a documented 35% reduction in claims-operations costs, not an emotional appeal — Empathy); owning an institutional relationship and then expanding the "loss taxonomy" to increase contract value (Empathy added Leave Support, pregnancy loss, and pet loss in 2025 — Empathy 2025 recap); and enterprise-distributed products with quantified partner ROI, such as Trust & Will's Fifth Third Bank partnership producing 39,000+ wills and $12.6M in customer savings in year one (Trust & Will).

What has failed: consumer subscriptions on a once-in-a-lifetime need (Lantern, Everplans); price transparency as a standalone business model (Parting's own CEO called it "not a surefire business model" before the company stopped updating its data — NY Post); content and audience without a transaction (Cake reached 100M+ users with no revenue model and was absorbed by a funeral chain); and hospice partnerships that were announced but never scaled past a pilot.

The white space: nobody offers nationwide, licensed, price-transparent, full-journey coordination with disclosed (not hidden) vendor economics. Every referral-fee arrangement found in this research — eFuneral's up-to-7.5% preneed rewards, Funeralocity's undisclosed Excellence Provider discounts, Ever Loved's reported affiliate commissions — is documented only on trade-facing partner pages, while the consumer-facing pages describe the same companies as free, impartial, or vetted with no mention of the financial relationship. Everest is the one clear exception, and it markets "no commissions from funeral homes or other providers" as a selling point to institutional buyers (BusinessWire). That disclosed-economics posture is a defensible, marketable wedge, and in Washington and New Jersey the undisclosed alternative is outright illegal (RCW 18.39.410; NJ Rev. Stat. 45:7-65.3).

Also unclaimed: the hospice and health-system channel. Medicare already obligates hospices to provide up to 13 months of bereavement follow-up with no dedicated reimbursement for it (42 CFR §418.64), which makes hospices structurally motivated to hand that burden to a tool like this one — yet no hospital or health-system partnership was confirmed for any competitor in this landscape, and the only hospice deals found (Empathy's Compassus pilot and NHPCO co-branded app) date to 2021 and are absent from Empathy's own 2025 highlights.

5. Target Customers and Payer Strategy

The user's question — market to families, hospitals, or nursing homes? — has a layered answer, because "who uses it" and "who pays for it" are different questions in this category.

Segment	Role	Why	Evidence
Families	End user, first market	Direct need, willing to pay a one-time fee for genuine relief from chaos	Consumer one-time fees ($99-$599) are the only consumer pricing model that survived in this category
Hospices	Highest-intent referral channel	Legally obligated to provide up to 13 months of bereavement support with no dedicated reimbursement; families are already in contact with hospice staff at the moment of death	42 CFR §418.64; channel confirmed as open in Section 4
Death doulas / independent funeral coordinators	Local service partner and lead source	Growing profession with no state licensure requirement, meaning fast partner onboarding; they already sit inside the family's decision process	No state requires death-doula licensure per this research; CA and IN consent orders barred funeral boards from demanding licensure of doulas
Employers / EAPs	B2B2C payer, second wave	84% plan to expand bereavement benefits; market clears at $0.75-$1.15 per-employee-per-month	Empathy 2026 report; Bereave pricing
Life insurers	B2B2C payer, third wave, largest contract value	99% of Empathy's business comes from this channel; pitch is claims-operations cost reduction	TechCrunch; Calcalist

Segment	Role	Why	Evidence
Nursing homes	Local referral partner	Frequent point of death for elderly residents; family is often already overwhelmed and receptive to a recommended tool at the moment of loss	Directionally supported by hospice-channel logic; no direct research evidence of an existing nursing-home partnership program in this category
Hospitals	Longer-term, unproven channel	Effectively open — no competitor has a confirmed hospital partnership — but hospital sales cycles and HIPAA business-associate requirements make this the slowest channel to develop	Confirmed absence of any hospital deal across all 17 competitors researched

Recommended sequencing: families first, in one metro, to prove the product works and to generate the case studies and usage data needed to sell into institutions. Hospices and independent death doulas/coordinators second, because they are low-friction, high-intent, and unclaimed. Employers and insurers third, once there is a working product and real usage metrics to make the ROI case. Nursing homes as an ongoing local referral layer alongside the hospice motion. Hospitals last, treated as a multi-year enterprise sales and compliance project, not a launch channel.

6. Death-to-One-Year Family Journey

This timeline is the backbone of the entire product — every feature, reminder, and permission decision in this plan maps back to a phase below.

Phase	Timeframe	Key tasks	Sources
Immediate	Days 0-7	Pronouncement of death, choice of disposition, ordering 8-15 certified death certificates ($5-$25 each), state-mandated waiting periods before cremation (TX 48hrs, AL 24hrs)	HelpAfterLife; Tex. Health & Safety Code § 716.004; Ala. Code § 34-13-121
Early administrative	Weeks 1-4	Report death to Social Security ($255 lump sum, <38% of deaths qualify, 2-year deadline), notify credit bureaus, notify banks and utilities	SSA Pub. 05-10008; CRS R43637; Equifax
Claims and benefits	Weeks 2-12	Life insurance claims (~30-day payout in nearly half of states), 401(k) beneficiary claims (death certificate + proof of relationship), VA burial benefits (Form 21P-530EZ, $2,000 service-connected / $1,002+$1,002 non-service-connected, 2-year deadline for non-service-connected)	Law Commentary; IRS; VA
Estate and legal	Months 1-18	Probate (6-12 months simple; 12-24 months with real property; 9-18 months court-published), attorney engagement, asset inventory	48HourProbate; LegalZoom
Tax deadlines	Months 4-15	Final Form 1040 (April 15 following death), Form 1041 estate income tax (April 15), Form 706 estate tax (9 months, extendable to 15 via Form 4768), Form 8971 (30 days after Form 706 due)	IRS; IRS, Form 706

Phase	Timeframe	Key tasks	Sources
One-year cluster	Months 9-15	Form 706 deadline window, probate status reports, SSA/VA two-year claim windows approaching, religious anniversary observances	IRS, Form 706; SSA; VA; SDSC PR-195; California Courts
Religious/cultural observance	Ongoing per tradition	Jewish: burial within 24hrs, shiva 7 days, sheloshim 30 days, mourning for a parent 11 months, unveiling before first yahrzeit. Muslim: burial within 24hrs, mourning 3 days, widow's iddah 4 months 10 days. Hindu: cremation within 24-48hrs, mourning 13 days, shraddha rites 10-12 days. Catholic: Vigil, Funeral Mass, Committal, anniversary Mass	My Jewish Learning; Wikipedia, Islamic funeral; The Living Urn; USCCB

This is precisely why a generic to-do app or a static PDF checklist does not solve the problem: the tasks span nearly two years, involve a dozen different institutions with different deadlines, and are conditioned on state law and religious practice simultaneously. The app's core value is compressing that complexity into one adaptive, permissioned workspace.

7. Product Vision and Architecture

The product is a family workspace, not a funeral marketplace and not a legal service. One family member — the coordinator — creates a case tied to the deceased, and the app generates a personalized roadmap by combining three inputs: the deceased's state of residence (and state of death, if different), the family's stated religious or cultural tradition, and the categories of assets involved (real property, life insurance, retirement accounts, military service). From that roadmap, the app surfaces tasks, deadlines, document checklists, and relevant local resources, and lets the coordinator delegate specific tasks to a small circle of invited helpers.

Architecturally, the product has four core modules:

1. **Family Workspace & Permissions** — the coordinator's control center, invitations, roles, task assignment, and audit trail (detailed in Section 9).
2. **Checklist & Timeline Engine** — the state/religion-aware task and deadline generator that drives the whole death-to-one-year journey (detailed in Sections 6 and 12).
3. **Resource & Legal/Financial Directory** — curated, jurisdiction-specific links, forms, and contacts for SSA, VA, IRS, probate courts, and attorney referral services (detailed in Section 11).
4. **Vendor & Coordinator Marketplace** — a directory of funeral homes, caterers, florists, and independent funeral coordinators/death doulas, with transparent (not hidden) partnership terms (detailed in Section 10).

8. MVP Feature Set

The MVP should be scoped tightly to Georgia, three to four major religious/cultural traditions (Protestant Christian, Catholic, Jewish, and one more relevant to Atlanta's demographics, such as Baptist or Muslim traditions), and a feature list that proves the core coordination value without triggering the heaviest compliance burdens.

Include in MVP:

- Coordinator account creation and case setup (deceased's state, date of death, religious/cultural preference, asset categories)
- Auto-generated, phase-based checklist per Section 6, editable and dismissible task by task
- Invite up to 4-5 helpers with role-based, time-limited access (Section 9)
- Shared document vault (death certificates, wills, insurance policies) with per-document visibility controls
- Curated legal/financial resource directory with direct links to SSA, VA, IRS forms, and a state-specific attorney referral directory (information only, never advice — Section 11)
- Vendor directory for funeral homes, florists, and caterers in Georgia with transparent partnership disclosure
- Shared expense ledger and simple decision log to reduce financial disputes
- Push/email/SMS reminders tied to deadlines (SSA 2-year window, VA 2-year window, Form 706 nine-month window, religious observance dates)

What not to build first: a licensed, nationwide funeral-arranging transaction engine (After.com spent $16.1M to reach only six states doing exactly this); any feature that tells a family what legal action to take rather than presenting information and attorney referrals (unauthorized-practice-of-law exposure, detailed in Section 14); and any vendor commission structure that is not disclosed to the family inside the app itself (the undisclosed-commission pattern is the single most consistent trust failure identified across competitors in Section 4).

9. Family Permissions and Feud-Reduction Design

This is the feature the user specifically asked for, and it should be treated as a primary design pillar, not an afterthought. The goal is to give one person real authority while preventing that authority from becoming a flashpoint, and to give helpers real usefulness while preventing chaos from too many people touching sensitive information.

Structure:

- **One coordinator** creates the case and holds default administrative rights. Coordinator status can be formally transferred (e.g., if the original coordinator becomes unavailable), with the transfer itself logged.
- **4-5 invited helper seats**, each assigned a defined role rather than blanket access: for example, Financial Helper (bills, insurance claims, expense ledger), Logistics Helper (funeral home, catering, flowers), Legal/Documents Helper (death certificates, probate paperwork, document vault), and Family Liaison (communication with extended family, obituary, memorial page).
- **Task ownership**: every task in the checklist can be assigned to a specific person, with status (not started, in progress, done) visible to all members — this alone resolves a large share of "who is supposed to be doing this" conflict.

- **Shared expense ledger:** every funeral- or estate-related expense logged in one place, visible to all members, closing the most common source of family disputes — money.
- **Decision log with approval gates:** significant decisions (choice of funeral home, casket/urn selection above a coordinator-set dollar threshold, memorial service date) can be configured to require acknowledgment or a lightweight approval from a defined subset of helpers before being marked final, creating a paper trail without requiring unanimous consent for every small decision.
- **Sensitive-only-to-coordinator fields:** certain information (full estate value, life insurance payout amount, specific account numbers) can be restricted to the coordinator alone, or to the coordinator plus one designated Financial Helper, rather than exposed to all 4-5 members by default.
- **Audit trail:** every access, edit, and permission change is logged and visible to the coordinator, so disputes about "who changed this" or "who saw that" can be settled with a record rather than an argument.
- **Time-limited and revocable access:** helper access can be set to auto-expire at defined milestones (e.g., 90 days post-funeral) or revoked manually by the coordinator, preventing indefinite access creep.

This design deliberately avoids full transparency-to-everyone (which research on family conflict during estate settlement consistently identifies as a trigger for resentment over unequal contribution or unequal inheritance) while also avoiding a single black box controlled by one person (which is the other classic trigger for family conflict). The combination of role-based tasks, a shared ledger, a decision log, and an audit trail gives the family structure without requiring a change in how they naturally divide labor.

10. Vendor Marketplace and Coordinator Network

The vendor marketplace should launch with funeral homes, florists, and caterers in the Georgia MVP market, recruited the same way Ever Loved and Funeralocity built their initial networks: free or low-cost listings in exchange for visibility, rather than upfront fees that discourage the ~75% of funeral homes that are small, independent, and family-owned (Ever Loved for funeral homes; Funeralocity).

Coordinator/death-doula network: independent funeral coordinators and death doulas are an underused local partner class — they are not licensed in any state (per this research) but sit directly inside the family's decision process at the moment of highest need, are typically small, community-embedded businesses eager for referral flow, and CA and IN consent orders have already established that funeral boards cannot demand funeral-director licensure of them. The app should recruit local coordinators/doulas as a referral partner tier, paying them for confirmed engagements rather than for app downloads, mirroring Everest's model of independent, non-commissioned professional guidance.

Commission structure — the critical differentiator: every disclosed and undisclosed commission arrangement in this category was reviewed in Section 4, and the consistent finding is that commission economics exist everywhere but are disclosed to consumers almost nowhere. This app should do the opposite: every vendor relationship and every fee the app

receives from a vendor should be visible to the family inside the product itself (e.g., "This funeral home pays a listing fee to appear here; we do not receive a commission on your purchase" or the reverse, clearly stated). This is both a legal necessity in states like Washington and New Jersey that restrict referral fees (RCW 18.39.410; NJ Rev. Stat. 45:7-65.3) and a marketing asset, since Everest has proven that "no commissions from funeral homes" is a sellable claim to institutional buyers.

11. Legal, Financial, and Resource Module

This module directly answers the user's request for "legal numbers or resources to contact based on the passing family member's assets, such as houses, properties, life insurance, 401(k), and military benefits," and it must be built inside a carefully drawn legal boundary.

What the app can safely provide (information, not advice):

- Direct links and instructions for SSA death reporting and the $255 lump-sum benefit application
- Direct links to VA Form 21P-530EZ and burial benefit eligibility criteria
- IRS form references and deadlines for Form 1040 (final), Form 1041, Form 706, and Form 8971
- State-specific probate court contact information and general process explanations
- An attorney referral directory (state bar association referral services or vetted local estate attorneys), letting the family choose and engage their own counsel
- Life insurance and 401(k) claim checklists listing the documents typically required (death certificate, proof of relationship, policy/account numbers), without advising on how to interpret specific plan terms
- Real property and mortgage checklists (notify mortgage servicer, review title, understand due-on-death considerations) framed as informational steps with a recommendation to consult an attorney or the mortgage servicer directly

What the app must not do:

- Tell a family what legal action to take, interpret how a specific will or trust applies to their situation, or resolve a legal dispute between family members — this is unauthorized practice of law in most states
- Act as the entity that "arranges" at-need funeral services if the app or its staff are not licensed funeral directors in a given state — several states, including Florida, treat "arranging" as a licensed act (Fla. Stat. § 497.372), and nine states require hiring a funeral director for at-need services (Funeral Consumers Alliance)
- Present itself as a substitute for an attorney without a conspicuous disclaimer; Texas law (§81.101(c)) provides an explicit software safe harbor that requires exactly this kind of notice, and the app should adopt that standard nationally regardless of state requirement

Every legal-adjacent screen in the app should carry a persistent, conspicuous notice: "This is general information, not legal advice. For advice specific to your situation, consult a licensed

attorney." That single design discipline is what separates a defensible information product from an unauthorized-practice-of-law liability.

12. State and Religion Checklist Strategy

The checklist engine is the app's central intellectual property, and it should be built as a rules-based combination of two independent input dimensions rather than as one checklist per state or one checklist per religion.

State dimension drives: death certificate ordering process and cost, cremation/burial waiting periods, whether hiring a licensed funeral director is legally required (9 states mandate this), probate process and typical timeline in that state's courts, and state-specific estate/inheritance tax rules if applicable.

Religious/cultural dimension drives: timing of burial or cremation relative to death, mourning period structure (shiva, iddah, sheloshim, shraddha, Catholic Vigil/Mass/Committal), specific rituals the family may want reminders for (unveiling before yahrzeit, anniversary Mass), and vendor recommendations suited to that tradition (e.g., a funeral home experienced with Jewish burial requirements).

The MVP should launch with Georgia as the only state and four traditions (a general/non-denominational Christian track, Catholic, Jewish, and one additional tradition reflecting Atlanta's demographic base) to prove the combinatorial engine works well before scaling the state and tradition matrix. Each additional state primarily requires updating the legal/administrative layer (death certificate process, probate court structure, licensing rules), while each additional tradition primarily requires updating the ritual/observance layer — meaning the two dimensions can scale independently once the engine is validated.

13. Technical Development Plan

Recommended stack: a cross-platform mobile app (React Native or Flutter) paired with a web companion (since older family members and attorneys may prefer web access), backed by a cloud infrastructure (AWS or GCP) sized for HIPAA/GLBA-adjacent compliance from day one rather than retrofitted later (see Section 14).

Core technical components:

- **Rules engine** for the checklist generator, structured as state-rule tables and tradition-rule tables that combine per case, rather than hardcoded per-combination checklists — this is what allows state and tradition expansion to scale independently
- **Role-based access control (RBAC)** system underlying the family permissions model in Section 9, with field-level (not just page-level) permission granularity for sensitive financial fields
- **Document vault** with per-document encryption and access logging, modeled on the security posture Trust & Will and Everplans have already established as the category

standard (AES-256 at rest, TLS 1.2+ in transit, SOC 2 Type II) (Trust & Will security; Everplans security)

- **Notification engine** capable of scheduling deadline-based reminders (SSA/VA two-year windows, Form 706 nine-month window) alongside recurring religious-observance reminders (annual yahrzeit, anniversary Mass)
- **Vendor directory and marketplace layer**, initially a curated directory with manual vetting in the Georgia MVP, evolving into a self-service vendor portal as the network grows
- **Admin/ops dashboard** for the internal team to manage vendor vetting, resource-directory accuracy (state forms and legal links change), and customer support escalations

Build sequencing: MVP (family workspace, checklist engine for Georgia + 4 traditions, document vault, basic vendor directory) in the first 90 days of engineering; permissions/audit trail hardening and expense ledger/decision log in the next phase; multi-state expansion and institutional-partner integrations (SSO for employer/insurer channels) only after MVP usage data justifies the investment.

Team needs: a small cross-functional team is sufficient for MVP — one product/founder lead, two to three full-stack engineers, one designer, and a part-time legal/compliance advisor familiar with funeral, probate, and UPL rules in Georgia specifically before expanding elsewhere.

14. Privacy, Security, and Compliance Plan

This is one of the highest-risk areas in the entire plan and must be treated as a first-class workstream, not a late-stage checkbox.

Federal Trade Commission Funeral Rule (16 CFR Part 453): binds anyone who sells both funeral goods and services, including unlicensed providers, and carries a maximum penalty of $53,088 per violation (FTC 2025 compliance guide). It is currently under periodic review with no Notice of Proposed Rulemaking issued as of the most recent public timetable (Reginfo Unified Agenda, RIN 3084-AB55), but enforcement is active — Damiano/Heritage Cremation paid a $275,000 penalty for posing as a local provider and failing to disclose third-party arrangements (FTC). Implication: the app should stay clearly on the "referral and coordination" side of this line rather than becoming a direct seller of funeral goods and services, at least until it is prepared to carry full Funeral Rule compliance (General Price List disclosure, etc.).

Licensing: funeral director licensure requires ABFSE-accredited education, the National Board Examination, and an apprenticeship (ABFSE FAQ); nine states require hiring a licensed funeral director for at-need arrangements (Funeral Consumers Alliance); "arranging" itself is a licensed act in states like Florida, which restricts selling, planning, or arranging at-need funeral services and making at-need financial arrangements to licensed funeral directors (Fla. Stat. § 497.372). The app must not perform licensed arranging activities itself — it connects families to licensed providers rather than acting as one, unless a future version deliberately pursues licensure state by state.

Death doulas: confirmed to have no licensure requirement in any state (NEDA FAQ; IEOLCA), and two states (California and Indiana) have specifically blocked funeral boards from imposing

funeral-director licensure requirements on them — California through a federal court consent order and Indiana through a state funeral board withdrawal (Institute for Justice; Bloomberg Law) — this is a genuine opportunity to build a partner network without a licensing bottleneck.

Unauthorized practice of law (UPL): the boundary is "legal information" versus "legal advice." Checklists, official government resource links, and attorney directories are safe; telling a family what legal action to take is not (Texas Courts, Legal Information vs. Legal Advice). Texas Gov't Code § 81.101(c) provides a software safe harbor — excluding from the definition of the practice of law the design and sale of software and similar products if the products clearly and conspicuously state that they are not a substitute for the advice of an attorney — that should be adopted as a baseline standard nationwide, not just where legally required (Texas Courts guidelines quoting § 81.101; UPL Committee v. Parsons Technology, 179 F.3d 956).

Privacy and data security: all 50 states have data breach notification laws, with 20 states requiring consumer notification within 30-60 days (Privacy Rights Clearinghouse, 2026 edition). The Gramm-Leach-Bliley Act Safeguards Rule likely applies once the app functions as a financial "finder" connecting families to insurance and financial claims, since the Rule was amended in 2021 to expressly cover finders (FTC Safeguards Rule guidance). HIPAA attaches specifically if the app forms a business-associate relationship with hospitals or hospices (HHS, Business Associates). The FTC's Health Breach Notification Rule, amended April 26, 2024 and effective July 29, 2024, extends breach-notification obligations to health-adjacent apps not otherwise covered by HIPAA, with penalties up to $51,744 per violation (FTC, HBNR Basics for Business; FTC final-rule announcement). The security bar already set by category leaders — AES-256 encryption at rest with per-user keys, TLS 1.2+ with perfect forward secrecy in transit, SOC 2 Type II examination, and an explicit commitment never to sell or share user information without consent — should be treated as the minimum viable security posture from day one, not an aspirational goal (Trust & Will security; Everplans security).

15. Monetization and Profitability Scenarios

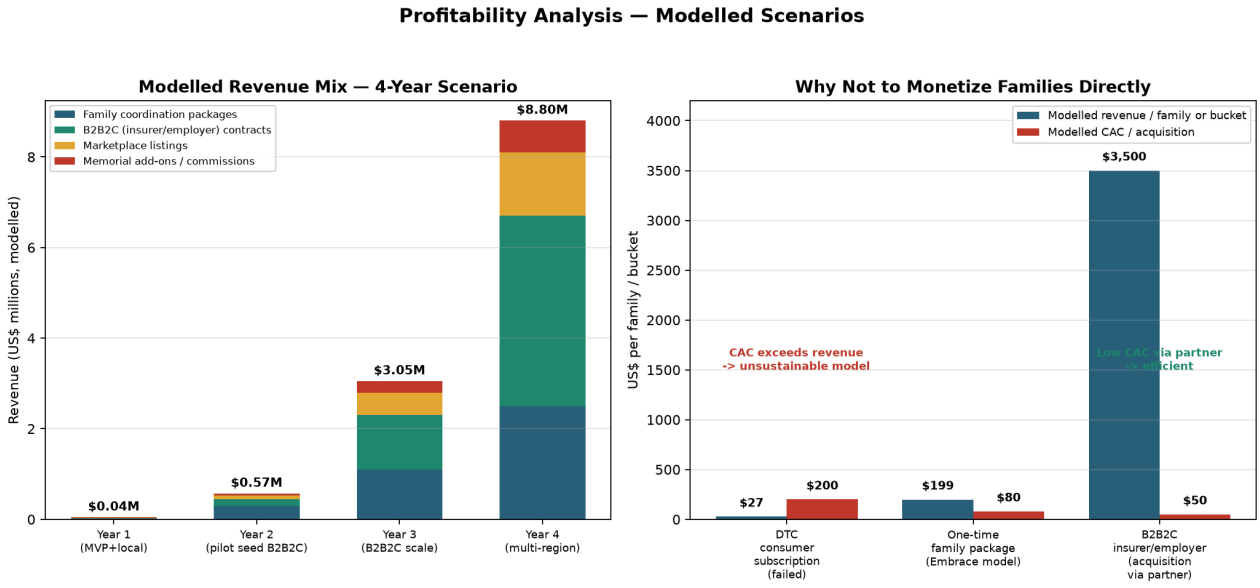
Important note on this section: the figures below are illustrative financial-model assumptions built on the pricing benchmarks and channel economics confirmed in the competitor and market research (Sections 3-4), not researched revenue projections for this specific, not-yet-built app. They are provided to show plausible order-of-magnitude outcomes under a reasonable set of assumptions, and should be revisited with real usage and conversion data as soon as the MVP launches.

Revenue streams:

1. **One-time family coordination package** — priced in the $99-$299 range, consistent with the only consumer price points that have survived in this category (Keeper $99 one-time, GoodTrust $149 flat, Ever Loved $199.99 one-time). A subscription model is deliberately avoided given the consistent, repeated failure of annual-subscription pricing in this exact category (Lantern, Everplans).
2. **B2B2C contracts** — sold to employers at the confirmed market-clearing rate of roughly $0.75-$1.15 per employee per month (Bereave's published pricing) or "pennies per employee per month" for a licensed-advisor tier (Everest's model), and to insurers at

enterprise contract value once the product has usage data to support an ROI pitch similar to Empathy's documented 35% claims-cost reduction.

3. **Disclosed marketplace listing fees** — charged to funeral homes, florists, and caterers for placement, following the free-to-low-cost listing model that built Ever Loved's and Funeralocity's initial networks, with all fee arrangements disclosed to families inside the app.
4. **Memorial and add-on services** — optional paid upgrades for memorial pages, tribute videos, or virtual/hybrid service coordination, an area where GatheringUs demonstrated families will pay $750-$2,300 for a fully produced service.



Note: illustrative financial model assumptions, not researched figures. Benchmarks: SCI avg funeral revenue $5,818; median funeral $6,280–$8,300; Empathy covers ~50M lives.

The chart's right panel illustrates why family-only monetization is structurally weak: a $27/year consumer subscription (Lantern's failed model) generates far less lifetime value than it costs to acquire a customer through paid channels, while an institutional partnership dramatically lowers acquisition cost per family because the insurer or employer distributes the product for you — the same structural advantage that let Empathy scale to 50M+ covered lives with 100% client retention.

Path to profitability: Year 1 should be treated as a proof-of-concept period focused on Georgia families and local coordinator/vendor partnerships, generating modest revenue primarily from one-time packages and vendor listings. Year 2 should focus on signing the first hospice, employer, or regional insurer pilot to validate the B2B2C motion. Years 3-4 scale the B2B2C channel as the primary growth and profitability engine, consistent with how every profitable or fast-growing company in this competitive set (Empathy, Trust & Will, Everest) actually built its business.

16. Go-to-Market Plan

Phase 1 — Georgia beachhead (families direct): Launch in Atlanta and greater Georgia with SEO-optimized content addressing the exact death-to-one-year questions families search for ("what to do when someone dies in Georgia," "Georgia probate timeline," "VA burial benefits Georgia"), paired with partnerships with a small number of local funeral homes, death doulas, and independent funeral coordinators who can refer families directly. This mirrors how Cake and Parting originally built consumer audiences through search, but with an actual monetization path this time.

Phase 2 — Hospice and coordinator network: Approach Georgia-based hospice organizations with the pitch that the app helps them fulfill their existing 13-month Medicare bereavement-support obligation more effectively at no cost to the hospice, positioning the app as a tool the hospice can recommend rather than a product it must buy — removing the sales friction that has stalled every hospice partnership attempt in this category so far.

Phase 3 — Employer and insurer B2B2C: Once Georgia usage data shows real family engagement and completion rates on the checklist journey, approach mid-market employers and regional insurers with a quantified pitch modeled on Bereave's transparent per-employee pricing and Empathy's claims-cost-reduction framing, rather than attempting to compete directly for the large national insurers already locked into Empathy's Alliance investor network.

Phase 4 — Nursing home referral layer and multi-state expansion: Add nursing homes as a local referral channel once the Georgia product is mature, and expand state by state, prioritizing states with large elderly populations and death volumes (Florida, California, Texas) and adding their state-specific legal/administrative rules to the checklist engine as each state is added.

Phase 5 — Hospital partnerships (long horizon): Treat hospital partnerships as a multi-year enterprise sales and HIPAA-compliance project, pursued only after the app has an established institutional track record with hospices and employers, since no competitor in this category has successfully closed a hospital partnership to date.

17. Operations and Staffing

MVP-stage team (Year 1): one founder/product lead, two to three engineers, one designer, one part-time legal/compliance advisor (Georgia-focused initially), and one operations/vendor-relations hire responsible for recruiting and vetting the initial Georgia funeral home, florist, caterer, and coordinator/doula network.

Growth-stage additions (Year 2+): a dedicated B2B2C sales hire once the employer/insurer motion begins, a customer support function specifically trained in trauma-informed communication (given the user base is, by definition, grieving), and a compliance/legal function that scales as the app expands into additional states with different licensing and probate rules.

Vendor and coordinator vetting: every funeral home, florist, caterer, and independent coordinator/doula listed in the marketplace should be manually vetted for licensing status (where applicable), complaint history, and pricing transparency before listing, following the credentialing approach Funeralocity uses for its Excellence Provider tier — but with full fee disclosure, which Funeralocity's own program does not consistently provide.

18. Risks and Mitigations

Risk	Why it matters	Mitigation
Unauthorized practice of law	Multiple competitors and industry rules draw a hard line between legal information and legal advice	Keep all legal-adjacent content as checklists, links, and attorney referrals only; conspicuous "not legal advice" disclaimers on every relevant screen, following the Texas §81.101(c) safe-harbor model
FTC Funeral Rule exposure	Applies to anyone selling funeral goods and services, including unlicensed sellers; penalties up to $53,088/violation and active enforcement	Stay on the referral/coordination side rather than directly selling funeral goods or services until the company is prepared for full compliance
Undisclosed vendor commissions eroding trust	Every competitor's undisclosed commission arrangement was identified as a trust liability in this research	Build in-app fee disclosure as a core design principle, and market it as a differentiator, not just a compliance requirement
Consumer-subscription revenue failure	Every annual-subscription consumer model in this category has been acquired or shut down	Use one-time family packages, not subscriptions, for consumer-facing pricing
Slow institutional sales cycles	Hospital and large-insurer sales cycles can take 12+ months and require extensive compliance review	Sequence GTM to generate revenue and usage proof from families, hospices, and local coordinators before betting on institutional deals
Data breach / privacy failure	50-state breach laws, potential GLBA and HIPAA exposure, and FTC Health Breach Notification Rule coverage	Build to the SOC 2 Type II / AES-256 / TLS 1.2+ security standard from day one; avoid HIPAA business-associate relationships until the compliance program can support them
Family conflict migrating into the app itself	The very problem the app is meant to solve (feuds and chaos) could resurface inside a poorly designed permissions system	Implement the role-based access, shared ledger, decision log, and audit trail design detailed in Section 9 as a core (not optional) feature from MVP
State-by-state legal and licensing complexity	Death certificate rules, probate processes, waiting periods, and licensing requirements vary significantly by state	Launch single-state (Georgia) first and expand deliberately, treating each new state as a discrete compliance project

19. Roadmap: 90 Days, 12 Months, 3 Years

First 90 days: Finalize Georgia-specific legal and compliance review (UPL boundaries, Funeral Rule posture, death-doula partnership terms); build the MVP family workspace, checklist engine (Georgia + 4 traditions), document vault, and basic vendor directory; recruit an initial cohort of 15-25 Georgia funeral homes, florists, caterers, and independent coordinators/doulas for the marketplace; begin SEO content build-out targeting Georgia-specific death-to-one-year search queries.

12 months: Launch publicly in Georgia; reach initial usage targets among Georgia families (tracked via the KPIs in Section 20); establish at least one hospice partnership pilot; refine the permissions/feud-reduction features based on real family usage; begin outreach to mid-market Georgia-based employers for an initial B2B2C pilot.

3 years: Expand the checklist engine to 5-10 additional states with the largest death volumes; convert the hospice pilot into a repeatable partnership playbook and expand to additional hospice organizations; sign the first regional or national employer/insurer B2B2C contracts; evaluate readiness for a first hospital partnership pilot; consider licensure or partnership structures that would allow the app to support at-need funeral arranging directly in states where doing so is both legal and strategically valuable.

20. Key Performance Indicators

Family engagement: percentage of created cases that complete at least the first 30 days of the checklist journey; average number of helpers invited per case (target 2-4, validating the permission model's real-world use); percentage of cases using the shared expense ledger and decision log (a proxy for whether the feud-reduction features are actually being adopted).

Monetization: conversion rate from free case creation to paid coordination package; average revenue per family case; vendor marketplace listing renewal rate; for the B2B2C channel, contract value per employer/insurer partner and per-covered-life cost, benchmarked against the $0.75-$1.15 PEPM and "pennies PEPM" figures confirmed in this research.

Channel health: number of active hospice and coordinator/doula referral partners; percentage of new cases originating from each channel (organic/SEO, coordinator referral, hospice referral, employer/insurer); vendor marketplace fill rate (percentage of listed categories with at least one vetted local vendor) in each active state.

Trust and compliance: number of documented complaints related to legal-advice boundary violations (target: zero); rate of disclosed versus total vendor fee arrangements (target: 100% disclosed); security incident count; state-by-state compliance review completion status as the app expands.

Research Limitations

Several figures in the underlying research could not be independently confirmed and were deliberately excluded rather than estimated, including Cake's exact operational status as of 2026 (competitor-marketing sites claim a June 2025 shutdown, but Cake's own site remains live), several competitors' total funding figures, and DTC grief-app customer acquisition cost benchmarks, which no source in this research could confirm. All revenue and profitability figures in Section 15 are explicitly labeled as illustrative financial-model assumptions rather than researched projections, since no company builds this specific product today and therefore no real performance data exists for it.